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RAJPUT RAGE
The Karni Sena celebrates Rana Sanga, whose legacy SP MP Suman contested

political landscape into a two-way contest, with the SP as the principal challenger to the BJP.

At the heart of it is a clear focus on consolidating Dalit support. This key voter base had swung in SP's direction in recent elections, but SP boss Akhilesh Yadav seems to realise he has no permanent lien on it—and that his 'PDA' ethos can be kept alive only through constant renewal. Those initials name a formula the SP used to expand its political force-field beyond the Yadav-Muslim base, with the 'D' putting Dalits at its centre. Needless to say, both the BSP—the original patent-holder on the Dalit vote—and the BJP have been edgy in their antagonism towards the SP's new vibe.

It first found a voice in the Rajya Sabha on March 21, when SP MP Ramji Lal Suman called 16th-century Rajput ruler Rana Sanga a "traitor" for allegedly inviting Babur to defeat Ibrahim Lodi, citing the Baburnama for good measure. A rebuttal to the "Babur's DNA" slur often hurled at Indian Muslims, he said: "You are also Rana Sanga's descendants—a traitor." On April 15, SP MLA Indrajeet Saroj, also a Dalit, questioned the power of Hindu deities in the context of historical invasions. "If our gods and goddesses were so powerful, why didn't they destroy those who looted this country?" he asked, declaring Ambedkar as his "real god".

TURNING THE TABLES

The backlash was predictable enough to be banked upon. Lurid bounties were offered. A Karni Sena infantry, armed with sticks, stones, reportedly even bulldozers, led a charge on Suman's residence in Agra. One worthy threatened to shoot Akhilesh. If the SP boss didn't blanch, it's because anything than can be predicted in politics can be an asset. Not only did he strongly defend his Dalit leaders, he called the Karni Sena acts "state-sponsored" and accused the BJP and UP CM Yogi Adityanath (a Rajput) of orchestrating caste-based attacks. Before the BJP realised it, the SP was framing the issue as a right-wing assault on Dalits/OBCs.

Political pundits spot a rationale here. When the BJP dipped from 62 to 33 seats in UP in the 2024 general election, it was ascribed to a Dalit-OBC swing towards the SP. It's a constituency the BJP needs badly to transcend its own elite-caste silo. Now it stands torn between the pizza base and the topping, where the real meat was. The delivery is threatening to go to a new address on the register. ■

Takeaways

- **The SP is making a bold bid to consolidate the Dalit support that has swung its way in the past few elections**
- **Defending Dalit leaders, it's framing the issue as a right-wing attack on Dalits/OBCs**



By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

A **PECULIAR GAP BETWEEN** ability and ambition has hobbled the West Bengal BJP for long. And that's after amassing acres of political space over the years. Its problem: the organisation that tends to this turf is wobbly on the inside. That's what Sunil Bansal, the party's minder for Bengal since mid-2022, aims to change ahead of the 2026 assembly election.

His ingredients—ideological commitment, grassroots connect, loyalty and systematic planning—may seem par for the course for any Sangh Parivar operation. But to see how it marks a strategic departure, simply contrast it to the chaotic legacy of Bansal's predecessor, Kailash Vijayvargiya: a controversial phase defined largely by the wholesale import of defectors. A spot of inorganic